50TH ANNIVERSARY

AAP
2005-2015



STREET OUTREACH
Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal at a public meeting in Delhi, Dec. 22, 2013

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

DAY OF THE AAM AADMI

From an anti-corruption crusade into a political force that successfully converted RTI activism and public anger into electoral power, the Aam Aadmi Party was once unassailable in the national capital but failed nationally against Modi's broader leadership appeal

The rise of the Aam Aadmi Party was neither sudden nor accidental. It was the political culmination of a decade-long moral revolt against corruption, institutional decay and elite impunity that marked India between 2005 and 2014. AAP grew out of the centre of public anger, shaped by the failures of governance during the UPA years and the inability of established parties to restore trust.

The turning point came with the explosion of mega-scams after 2008. The 2G spectrum scandal, Commonwealth Games irregularities and later Coalgate shattered the moral authority of the UPA government. The India Against Corruption movement, led publicly by Anna Hazare and operationally by Arvind Kejriwal and his associates, transformed grievance into mobilisation. The 2011 hunger strikes at Jantar Mantar and Ramlila Maidan were unprecedented in scale for a non-party agitation in urban India. Middle-class citizens, students, professionals and first-time protesters occupied public spaces, demanding a Jan Lokpal as a symbol of institutional cleansing. Parliament was forced into a rare special debate, a sign that street pressure had breached the gates of the legislature.